A KASHI CONUNDRUM

1991: The first petition, demanding the 'right to worship' for devotees at Gyanvapi mosque, filed by 'Swayambhu Jyotirlinga Bhagwan Vishweshwar' in a Varanasi court

AUG. '21: The Gyanvapi case is revived after five women Hindu devotees file a petition in a Varanasi court seeking permission to worship the deities Hanuman, Nandi and Shringar Gauri inside the mosque complex. The petition also wants "restrictions" put in place to "prevent damage to the idols"

APR. '22: Based on the 2021 petition, the Varanasi court appoints an advocate commissioner and also orders a video survey of the complex. The decision is challenged by the Anjuman Intezamia Masjid Committee (AIMC) in the Allahabad HC. But the HC upholds the order

MAY 6, '22: Video survey by the ASI begins a day ahead of the filing of an application by the AIMC alleging bias by advocate commissioner **Ajay Mishra**



MAY 17, '22: The court removes Mishra for 'leaking details' of the video survey, especially a purported shivling, and seeks all survey findings

MAY 19, '22: SC issues a stay order on the ASI survey, directs that all findings till that point be submitted before Varanasi court



OCT. 14, '22: Varanasi district court rejects plea for carbon dating of purported shivling found by survey. AIMC rejects finding, says shivling is actually a fountain used for wuzu ablutions

MAY 12, '23: Allahabad HC orders a "scientific survey" and tests to determine age of purported shivling

MAY 19, '23: Apex court defers the test on shivling



AUG. 3, '23: Allahabad HC lifts stay on ASI survey at the Gyanvapi mosque, says "scientific survey is in the interests of justice"

JUL. 24, '23: SC halts ASI's survey at premises, asks high court to hear the AIMC plea

JUL. 21, '23: Varanasi district court directs ASI to conduct survey—including excavations, if necessary—to determine if the mosque was built at a place where a temple existed earlier

YOGI'S STATEMENT SUGGESTS THAT THE BJP WILL PITCH THE GYANVAPI ISSUE AGGRESSIVELY AS 2024 NEARS

turn, come in response to an August 2021 petition by five women devotees claiming the presence of Hindu idols inside the mosque complex and their right to worship it. Last year, after a complicated legal tangle, the Supreme Court had stayed a video survey and referred the matter back to the local court (see *A Kashi Conundrum*).

Yogi's statement also hinted that the BJP may pitch the issue aggressively as the 2024 general election nears, similar to how they raised the heat on Ayodhya in 2019. Party sources confirm the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) too is backing Yogi. BJP leaders and sants of several hues have already come out with statements defending Yogi. Mahant Ravindra Puri, president of the Akhil Bharatiya Akhara Parishad, a governing body of Hindu seers, says, "Give us Gyanvapi and we'll build another mosque for you (the Muslims). Their religious leaders should show a big heart, lead by example so that future generations can feel proud of themselves. The Muslim clerics should hand over Gyanvapi to Hindu devotees so we can proceed with mutual consent."

On the other side, Lok Sabha MP and chief of the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM), Asaduddin Owaisi, says, "CM Adityanath knows the Muslims have opposed the ASI survey in the Allahabad High Court and that a judgment on it was due anytime in the next few days. Even then, he put out such a controversial statement...this is overreach."

Maulana Mohammad Suleman, a founding member of the All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB), too, feels that the Uttar Pradesh CM should not have issued such a statement in a case involving a religious place of such significance, especially when the matter is sub judice. "Yogiji's one-sided statements seem to be an attempt to divide society in time